

# Recipe for Growth

For Colgate-Palmolive's Prabha Narasimhan, it is important to always challenge the status quo

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

**IN DECEMBER 2021**, Prabha Narasimhan was in a hotel room in Mumbai when her mobile phone rang. It was from an unfamiliar number, and at the other end was a headhunter with a proposal.

Recalling the conversation, she admits to being very comfortable then in her position at Hindustan Unilever (HUL). As Executive Director, she was in the top management bracket and had no reason to leave, after almost 25 years with HUL, with a short stint at Madura Garments in between.

56 | The offer was to be MD & CEO

## WHAT KEEPS ME GOING

The ability to create a positive impact

## A LIFE LESSON LEARNT ON THE JOB

It is important to be clear about one's priorities and that means one can take the right decisions on both family and career



## PRABHA NARASIMHAN

51, MD & CEO, Colgate-Palmolive (India)

of Colgate-Palmolive (India). Colgate, its flagship brand, had about a 50 per cent share of the toothpaste market. "There was no push factor but tremendous pull," says Narasimhan in her corner office in Mumbai's Powai area. Called Colgate Research Centre, it is an impressive building with an informal culture, without any indication of being a ₹5,188-crore company (in terms of net sales with a gross margin of over 65 per cent).

So, what convinced her? Three factors, she says. "Colgate is a spectacular brand. Plus, there was a clear convergence of values and ethics," she explains. To top that up there was "a huge opportunity to do a lot". The deal was sealed by February 2022; the three months of gardening leave had her visit Colgate's offices in six countries. "I was struck by how similar the culture was. When I finally joined last September, there was already a lot of warmth and inclusivity," says the IIM Bangalore alumna.

A dominant position in toothpastes and a robust oral care business could easily lead to a feeling of complacency. But her drive comes from having run very profitable businesses at HUL that enjoyed a similar standing in the market. "One must always question the status quo and that really excites me," she says. Colgate has been in India since 1937 and there is still a lot to be done given where oral care is in the country, she says. As for Palmolive, synonymous with body wash and shower gels, the canvas is much larger. "As a company, we have a large product portfolio globally and can bring that to India," she says.

The job on hand now is to enhance the consumer base and get the existing ones to use the brand more often. With her drive and road map for growth, Narasimhan seems all set for success. **BT**

@krishnagopalan

